

Face Value

Madhusudan Mukerjee

madhusudan.mukerjee@thinkdigit.com

Lately, India and several other countries in the world have been the targets of terrorist attacks – *kamikaze* conspiracies that have destroyed innocent lives and public property. People and governments all over the world are gearing up to fight this menace and protect the innocent, and the answer lies in technology – and biometrics in particular, which is universally accepted as the one sure-fire way to ensure the protection and security of vulnerable populations and hopefully, someday, the elimination of terrorism altogether.

From fingerprints to faceprints

Biometrics, or the measurement and analysis of biological data, is that arm of technology that could ensure a safer world, if scientists are to be believed. Biometrics refers to the technologies of identifying, recording and correlating characteristics of the human body such as fingerprints, eye retinas and irises, voice patterns, palm geometry and DNA. Fingerprints, one of the oldest forms of biometric analysis, were used in 14th century China and subsequently by 20th century police, and are still an unavoidable ingredient in pulp-detective fiction and TV shows.

For more than a decade now, technologists, researchers and startups all over the world seem convinced that the unique features of the face can be constructively used by artificial intelligence – computers could create more foolproof security systems. Facial structures, when translated into mathematical descriptions, could help security agencies to face up to the post-9/11 threats of infiltration into public spaces by suspected criminals. Face detection and face-tagging are already familiar to us as the wow-features of our digital cameras, photo-sharing sites such as iPhoto, Flickr and Picasa and the not-so-foolproof VeriFace facial recognition login function of Lenovo's notebooks.

Image: Chaitanya Surpur

Your face is your destiny